

IRON MIND

FOR PARENTS

THE COMPLETE
PARENT PLAYBOOK
FOR STUDENT-
ATHLETES



SUPPORTING
THEIR
PERFORMANCE.



PREPARING
THEIR FUTURE.



PROTECTING
THEIR IDENTITY.

STRONGER TODAY. | PREPARED TOMORROW. | BEYOND THE SPORT.

The Athlete Check ParentsTM

BUILDING ATHLETES BEYOND THE SPORT



ABOUT THE FOUNDER

KEN STODDART

Leader. Coach. Counselor. Advocate.
Building Athletes Beyond the Sport.

Ken Stoddart is a former executive, performance coach, and mental health counselor who dedicated his life to helping student-athletes succeed on the field—and in life.



EXECUTIVE LEADERSHIP

A proven track record in executive leadership, business development, and organizational growth across multiple industries.
Strategic. Disciplined. Results-driven.



IDENTITY TRANSFORMATION

Ken experienced firsthand the power—and the pressure—of athletic identity. That experience shaped his mission to help athletes build a strong identity beyond sport.
From personal experience to purposeful mission.



ADVANCED EDUCATION

Master's Degree in Clinical Mental Health Counseling
Knowledge. Compassion. Commitment to lasting impact.



“

One day every athlete faces a final whistle. The question isn't what they accomplished. The question is who they became.

– Ken Stoddart



OUR MISSION

We help families support performance, protect identity, and prepare athletes for life beyond sport.



We believe student-athletes are more than athletes.



We equip families with the tools to make a lasting difference.



We prepare athletes for their greatest game—life.



**STRONG TODAY.
PREPARED FOR TOMORROW.**

Excellence in sport. Clarity in identity. Purpose in life.

ABOUT THE FOUNDERS



LUKE STENSON
CO-FOUNDER

A Division I student-athlete and leader on and off the field, Luke knows what it means to push limits, face adversity, and inspire others.

*STUDENT-ATHLETES, LEADERS,
ADVOCATES, CHANGEMAKERS.*

OUR MISSION

WHY WE EXIST

We believe student-athletes are more than athletes. They are leaders, students, teammates, family members, and future professionals.

TheAthleteCheck was created to provide the tools, resources, and support student-athletes need to thrive—both in sport and in life.



WYATT PORCH
CO-FOUNDER

A Division I swimmer and mental health advocate, Wyatt has seen firsthand the pressure student-athletes face and is passionate about creating meaningful change.



MENTAL HEALTH

We promote mental wellness, resilience, and emotional strength to help athletes handle life's challenges with confidence.



IDENTITY DEVELOPMENT

We help athletes build a strong, healthy identity beyond sport so they are prepared for life after the game.



PERFORMANCE SUPPORT

We provide strategies, resources, and guidance to help athletes perform at their best while protecting their wellbeing.

BUILDING ATHLETES BEYOND THE SPORT



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A complete roadmap to help you support, empower, and prepare your student-athlete for [life beyond sport](#).



WELCOME TO THE IRONMIND JOURNEY

This playbook is built on the belief that athletes are more than their sport.

Inside, you'll find practical strategies, powerful conversations, and reflection tools to help you strengthen your relationship, support their mental performance, and prepare them for a meaningful future.

**Same Team.
Different Roles.
One IronMind.**



The goal isn't to create perfect athletes. It's to raise resilient humans.

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INSIDE THE MIND OF YOUR ATHLETE

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YOUR ROLE MATTERS.

Your support today shapes their confidence tomorrow and their future for a lifetime.

**STRONGER TODAY.
EMPOWER
TOMORROW.
IMPACT FOREVER.**

INSIDE THE MIND OF YOUR ATHLETE

WHAT THEY FEEL BUT DON'T SAY

Before parents can effectively support performance, they must understand identity.

Every athlete carries invisible pressures, private fears, personal expectations, and beliefs that shape how they compete, respond to adversity, and see themselves.

This section explores the psychological forces behind athletic identity and helps parents better understand the person behind the player.



ATHLETIC IDENTITY

How athletes define themselves beyond their sport.



HIDDEN PRESSURES

The expectations, stressors, and fears athletes rarely discuss openly.



MINDSET & BELIEFS

Internal narratives that shape confidence, decisions, and performance.



PARENT AWARENESS

Practical insights for supporting healthy development and lifelong growth.



The quality of a parent's **understanding** is the quality of an athlete's **foundation**.

— KEN STODDART



ATHLETIC IDENTITY WHEEL

8 AREAS. 1 IDENTITY. A LIFETIME OF IMPACT.

Each area of the wheel influences how your athlete sees themselves and shows up in the world.

Use this wheel as a guide for meaningful conversations, focused support, and intentional growth.



REFLECTION PROMPT

Which areas of the wheel are your athlete's strengths?
Which areas need more support right now? How can you help create balance across all 8 areas?

ATHLETIC IDENTITY WHEEL

8 AREAS. 1 IDENTITY. A LIFETIME OF IMPACT.

When all 8 areas are nurtured and aligned, your athlete develops confidence, resilience, and purpose—on and off the playing field.



REFLECT

Where is your athlete strong right now?



IDENTIFY

Where do they need more support?



PLAN

What small steps can create growth?



SUPPORT

How can you walk alongside them?



CELEBRATE

Recognize progress, not just outcomes.

Identity isn't just who they are on the field—it's who they are becoming in life.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The
Athletic Identity Wheel™



REFLECTION & NEXT STEPS

What 1-2 areas do you feel your athlete needs more support in right now?

What strengths can you build on to support their growth?

What is one action you can take this week to help them grow in a key area?



UNDERSTANDING IDENTITY: THE FOUNDATION FOR LIFE BEYOND SPORT

Athletic identity is how much of who your athlete believes they are is tied to being an athlete.

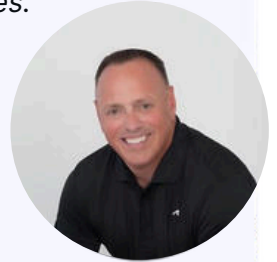
A strong identity is not about being the best on the field. It's about knowing who you are in every area of life. The Athletic Identity Wheel™ helps athletes build a whole, balanced identity—one that lasts a lifetime.

“

When athletes build identity in all areas of life, they gain freedom, confidence, and the ability to thrive—no matter the circumstances.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The
Athletic Identity Wheel™



THE THREE LEVELS OF IDENTITY



1. ATHLETE IDENTITY

The role of being an athlete. Important, but only one part of who they are.



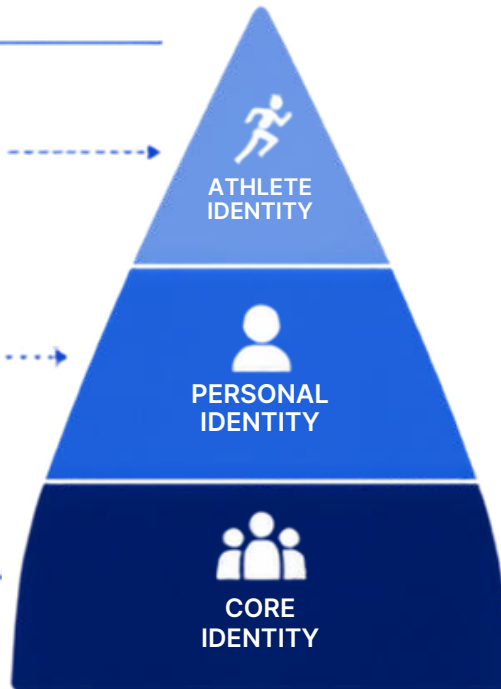
2. PERSONAL IDENTITY

Traits, values, interests, relationships, and beliefs that shape who they are as a person.



3. CORE IDENTITY

Their deeper sense of self-purpose, worth, and character. This is the foundation that never changes.



A STRONG FOUNDATION SUPPORTS EVERY PART OF THE JOURNEY.

WHY IT MATTERS



BUILD RESILIENCE

A strong identity helps athletes bounce back from setbacks.



INCREASE CONFIDENCE

Knowing who they are creates unshakable self-belief.



PREPARE FOR TRANSITIONS

Life beyond sport becomes an exciting new chapter, not a loss.



FIND LASTING PURPOSE

Purpose comes from within, not from trophies or recognition.



PARENT REFLECTION

Which level of identity do you think your athlete relies on most right now? _____
How does your athlete respond when they can't participate in their sport? _____
What non-sport strengths or interests do you see in your athlete? _____
How can you help support a more balanced, whole identity? _____



*Identity isn't something you find.
It's something you build—intentionally, every day.*

— KEN STODDART

WHEN ATHLETIC IDENTITY BECOMES A RISK

Athletic identity is powerful.
But when it becomes an athlete's only identity,
it can create pressure, anxiety, and fear.
It can put their wellbeing and future at risk.



WARNING SIGNS



Performance defines self-worth.
They feel valuable only when
they perform.



Injury creates an identity crisis.
Without sport, they feel lost
or confused.



Sport becomes the only source
of confidence.
Their mood and self-esteem
depend on outcomes.



Fear of failure increases.
Pressure to perform grows,
and enjoyment fades.



Transition becomes
overwhelming.
Life after sport feels uncertain
and scary.



PARENT INSIGHT

Healthy athletes have
multiple sources of identity.



Family
I am loved.



Character
I am built on
strong values.



Relationships
I belong and
connect.



Leadership
I can lead
and inspire.



Community
I can make a
difference.



Purpose
I have meaning
and direction.



Sport
I compete and
grow.

When identity is balanced, athletes are
stronger on and off the field.



The goal is not to remove athletic
identity.
The goal is to expand it.

— Ken Studdart



Keep in Mind

Your athlete is more than their
sport.
Help them build a life they love,
not just a career they chase.

**SPORT SHOULD BE PART OF THEIR IDENTITY.
NOT THEIR ENTIRE IDENTITY.**

A strong identity today
creates a confident future.

BUILDING A WHOLE IDENTITY:

5 CORE PRINCIPLES

A strong athletic identity is built intentionally. These five principles guide the process.

When these principles are present, athletes develop the confidence, resilience, and clarity to navigate sport—and life—with purpose.

“

We don't wait our athletes to just perform well in sport.

We want them to become strong, confident, and purposeful in life.

— KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The
Athletic Identity Wheel™



THE 5 PRINCIPLES OF IDENTITY DEVELOPMENT

1



BE INTENTIONAL

Identity doesn't happen by accident. It's built through intention, focus and daily choices in every area of life.

KEY ACTION

Make identity development a priority, not an afterthought.

2



NURTURE ALL 8 AREAS

Growth happens when all areas of the wheel are nurtured and branded—not just the athletic ones.

KEY ACTION

Invest time and energy in all areas, not just sport.

3



BUILD ON STRENGTHS

Strengths build confidence. Confidence builds resilience. Focus on developing what your athlete does well.

KEY ACTION

Identify strengths and create more opportunities to use them.

4



SURROUND WITH THE RIGHT PEOPLE

The right people influence, encourage, and challenge. Think of the kind of person your athlete becomes.

KEY ACTION

Build a circle of mentors, teammates, and friends who lift them up.

5



CONNECT TO PURPOSE

Purpose gives direction and motivation. It turns everyday choices into meaningful steps.

KEY ACTION

Help your athlete discover what matters most to them.

PARENT REFLECTION PROMPT



Which of these five principles do you feel strongest in right now? _____

Which principle do you struggle with the most? _____

What is one action you can take this week to better support your athlete's identity? _____



Your athlete's identity is the foundation for everything they will build in life.

— KEN STODDART

REFLECTION WORKSHEET

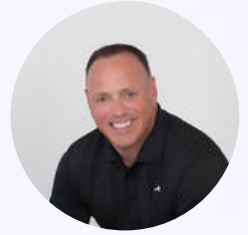
BUILDING A WHOLE IDENTITY

Use this worksheet to reflect on your athlete's identity journey and how you can support their growth in all 8 areas of the Athletic Identity Wheel™.

“

Reflection creates awareness.
Awareness creates choice.
Choice creates change.
And change builds stronger,
more confident athletes.

— KEN STODDART



PART 1: AWARENESS

For each area of the Athletic Identity Wheel™, reflect on where your athlete is now.
Use the following scale:

1 — NEEDS SUPPORT
3 — DEVELOPING
5 — STRONG

8 AREAS	HOW WOULD YOU DESCRIBE YOUR ATHLETE RIGHT NOW?	RATING (1-5)
 MINDSET How confident and resilient is your athlete mentally?		☐
 VALUES Do they understand and live by their core values?		☐
 EDUCATION Are they engaged in learning and preparing for their future?		☐
 CAREER & PURPOSE Do they explore interests and have a passion for purpose?		☐
 LIFE SKILLS How strong are their life skills like communication, time management, or purpose?		☐
 PHYSICAL WELLNESS Are they taking care of their body and health?		☐
 SPIRITUALITY Do they have a sense of meaning, gratitude, or connection?		☐
 RELATIONSHIPS Are they surrounded by positive, supportive relationships?		☐

PART 2: REFLECTION

What are 2–3 areas where your athlete is thriving?

What are 2–3 areas where they might need more support?

What strengths can you build on to support their growth?

PART 3: INTENTION

What is one action you can take this week to support your athlete in one area of their identity?

How will this action help them grow beyond sport?

How will you celebrate progress, not just outcomes?

You can't build a legacy on the field if your identity only exists on the field.

— KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Mindset Wheel™



THE IRONMIND MENTALITY™

STRONG MINDS. STRONGER FUTURES.

The IronMind Mentality™ is the foundation of everything an athlete becomes—on and off the field.

It's not about being perfect.
It's about being prepared.
It's not just about performance.
It's about purpose.

WE BUILD ATHLETES.
WE BUILD CONFIDENCE.
WE BUILD CHARACTER.
WE BUILD IRONMINDS.



“

The IronMind Mentality™ isn't something you find. It's something you build—one decision, one challenge, one day at a time.

— KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel™

WHAT'S AHEAD

-  IronMind Mentality™
-  Foundations Communication That Connects
-  Mindset, Identity Performance, Life.
-  A Pledge for the Journey Ahead

The right mindset changes everything.
The IronMind Mentality makes it last.



Explore more tools and resources to support your athlete's journey.

TheAthleteCheck.com

WHAT IS THE IRONMIND MENTALITY?

A MINDSET BUILT FOR LIFE—ON AND OFF THE FIELD.

The IronMind Mentality is a comprehensive mental performance framework that helps athletes develop the inner strength, clarity, and confidence needed to thrive in sport and in life.

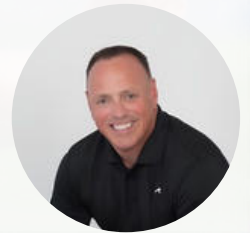
It's not about avoiding pressure. It's about building the mindset to grow through it.

“

You can't always control what happens to you, but you can control how you think about it and how you respond.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic
Identity Wheel !



THE IRONMIND FOUNDATION

The IronMind Mentality rests on five interconnected pillars that shape how athletes think, feel, and perform.



STRONG MINDSET

Build belief, confidence, and mental resilience to face challenges with courage.



CLEAR IDENTITY

Know who you are, what you value, and what you stand for—on and off the field.



PURPOSE DRIVEN

Play with meaning. Set goals that matter and pursue excellence for a greater purpose.



RELATIONSHIP SMART

Build strong connections, communicate with respect, and contribute to a positive team culture.



LIFE READY

Develop skills for life—time management, leadership, adaptability, and emotional well-being.

MORE THAN SPORT

While performance matters, the IronMind Mentality prepares athletes for far more than wins and losses.

- ✓ It builds character.
- ✓ It strengthens decision-making.
- ✓ It prepares athletes for life's biggest moments.

THIS IS THE MINDSET THAT LASTS.

WHY IT MATTERS NOW

Today's athletes face more pressure, more distractions, and more challenges than ever before.

Over 70% of athletes report feeling overwhelmed by pressure and expectations.

Distraction and comparison are stealing focus and confidence.

The right mindset is the #1 predictor of long-term success and well-being.

THE IRONMIND MENTALITY IS THE DIFFERENCE.

**STRONGER MINDS.
STRONGER FUTURES.**

THAT'S THE IRONMIND MENTALITY .

BUILT ON SCIENCE. PROVEN IN SPORT. DESIGNED FOR LIFE.

The IronMind Mentality integrates sports psychology, neuroscience, and real-world application to help athletes perform with confidence and live with purpose.

Explore more tools
and resources at
TheAthleteCheck.com

THE CHARACTERISTICS OF AN IRONMIND ATHLETE™

BUILT FROM THE INSIDE OUT.

IronMind athletes don't just perform at a high level—they grow at a high level. These characteristics define how they think, how they lead, and how they show up in sport and in life.



EIGHT CHARACTERISTICS. ONE IRONMIND.

1



MENTALLY TOUGH

They stay calm under pressure, bounce back from setbacks, and embrace hard challenges.

2



FOCUSED

They block distractions, stay in the moment, and prioritize what matters most.

3



CONFIDENT

They believe in themselves, trust their training, and step up when it counts.

4



RESILIENT

They adapt, persevere, and keep moving forward no matter what.

5



TEAM-FOCUSED

They lead with respect, communicate well, and put the team first.

6



DISCIPLINED

They commit to the process, do the work daily, and hold themselves accountable.

7



PURPOSE DRIVEN

They play with meaning, set big goals, and want to make a positive impact.

8



LIFE READY

They build skills for life—leadership, time management, and emotional awareness.



OUR COMMITMENT AS PARENTS

We will help our athletes grow these characteristics through support, encouragement, and intentional conversations. The IronMind Mentality™ starts at home and grows everywhere.

- ✓ Model these characteristics.
- ✓ Reinforce effort, growth, and values.
- ✓ Celebrate progress, not just outcomes.
- ✓ Prepare them for life, not just sport.

THE IRONMIND PERFORMANCE PYRAMID

What Great Athletes Are Really Built On



IRONMIND INSIGHT

Most parents
focus on the top
of the pyramid.

Elite development
begins at the
bottom.

- ✓ **Identity** creates stability.
- ✓ **Support** creates growth.
- ✓ **Habits** create consistency.
- ✓ **Mental skills** create performance.

LEVEL 5

ELITE PERFORMANCE

Championship moments.
Game-day execution.
Peak performance.

LEVEL 4

MENTAL TOUGHNESS

- Resilience
- Confidence
- Focus
- Emotional Control

LEVEL 3

DAILY HABITS

- Discipline
- Consistency
- Preparation
- Accountability

LEVEL 2

SUPPORT SYSTEM

- Parent Support
- Coach Relationships
- Mentorship
- Healthy Communication

FOUNDATION

IDENTITY

- Values
- Character
- Purpose
- Self-Worth
- Beyond Sport

"Strong athletes
are built from the
foundation up—
not the spotlight
down."

— Ken
Stoddart



PERFORMANCE IS THE RESULT.
IDENTITY IS THE FOUNDATION.

HOW PARENTS BUILD THE PYRAMID

Every Layer Requires Intentional Support



RESEARCH INSIGHT

Athletes with strong identity development and supportive family environments demonstrate greater resilience, higher enjoyment, and improved long-term wellbeing.

—Journal of Applied Sport Psychology

PARENT REFLECTION

Which layer of the pyramid is strongest in our family?

Which layer needs the most attention?

What is one action I will take this week?

“

The goal is not to raise successful athletes.

The goal is to raise successful people who happen to be athletes.”

— Ken Stoddart

**BUILD THE FOUNDATION.
PERFORMANCE WILL FOLLOW.**

Every conversation. Every habit. Every choice. You are building more than performance. You are building a life.

PARENT COMMUNICATION FRAMEWORK

YOUR WORDS, THEIR MINDSET, THEIR FUTURE.

The way we communicate with our athletes shapes how they think, feel, and perform. Use this framework to lift them up, build confidence, and strengthen your relationship—on and off the field.



	 GREEN EXAMPLES WHAT TO SAY / DO	 RED EXAMPLES WHAT TO AVOID
 FOCUS Keep the focus on effort, growth, and the process.	"I love watching you play." "What did you learn today?" "I'm proud of how hard you worked." "How did that make you feel?"	"Did you win?" "Why didn't you score more?" "You need to do better." "What's wrong with you today?"
 EFFORT Recognize hustle, preparation, and persistence.	"I saw how hard you played." "You never gave up there." "Your practice is paying off." "You stayed focused the whole game."	"You were so lazy today." "You only played well in the first half." "You're not trying hard enough." "Why can't you be more like?"
 MINDSET Build confidence and resilience through your words.	"Mistakes help you learn and grow." "What will you do better next time?" "You've got this." "I believe in you."	"You always make mistakes." "Don't mess this up." "You choke under pressure." "I'm losing faith in you."
 EMOTIONS Validate feelings and teach emotional awareness.	"It's okay to feel disappointed." "I'm here for you." "Take a breath. Reset. You've got this." "How can I support you right now?"	"Stop being so emotional." "It's not a big deal." "Don't cry." "Toughen up."
 RELATIONSHIP Be their biggest fan, not their biggest critic.	"Thanks for letting me be part of your journey." "I'm grateful to be your parent." "I'm on your team, always." "I enjoy our time together."	"You're embarrassing me." "I've sacrificed so much for you." "Do this for me." "You don't appreciate anything I do."

COMMUNICATION TIPS

-  Listen more than you talk.
-  Ask open-ended questions.
-  Pause before you react.
-  Keep emotions in check.
-  Speak to build up, not tear down.
-  Remember: they're listening, even when they don't respond.

THE IRONMINDTM PARENT PLEDGE

I WILL BUILD THEIR MIND.
I WILL STRENGTHEN THEIR FUTURE.

As a parent, I play a powerful role in shaping my athlete's mindset, character, and future. I commit to creating an environment where they can grow on and off the field.

“

The strongest athletes are built by parents who lead with love, purpose, and IronMind.

— KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel™



AS AN IRONMIND PARENT, I PLEDGE TO:



LEAD THEIR MINDSET

I will help my athlete build a strong mindset based on self-awareness, confidence, and a clear sense of purpose.



CELEBRATE THE PROCESS

I will celebrate effort, improvement, and character—not just results. I understand that growth happens one step at a time.



COMMUNICATE WITH PURPOSE

I will use words that encourage, support, and build confidence. I will listen more than I talk and ask better questions.



SUPPORT THEIR JOURNEY

I will be their biggest fan, not their biggest critic. I will trust their coaches and respect the process.



BUILD RESILIENCE

I will help my athlete embrace challenges, learn from setbacks, and stay resilient through every season of their journey.



MODEL THE STANDARD

I will model the values I want my athlete to live by—integrity, respect, responsibility, and compassion.



FOCUS ON THE WHOLE PERSON

I will care about my athlete as a person first, not just as a player. Their character matters more than their stats.



HONOR THE IRONMIND MENTALITY™

I will commit to the IronMind Mentality™ and help create an environment where they can thrive in sport and life.



MY COMMITMENT

I understand that my athlete's journey is not just about the game—it's about the person they become. I commit to being the parent who builds their mind, strengthens their character, and prepares them for life.



PARENT/GUARDIAN NAME (PRINT)

SIGNATURE

DATE

BUILDING A FUTURE BEYOND SPORT

The ultimate goal is not simply helping athletes succeed in competition.

It is helping them build the confidence, character, skills, and identity needed to thrive long after the final whistle.



One day every athlete will play their final game. Our responsibility is preparing them for everything that comes next.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel™



EDUCATION

Help them develop knowledge, curiosity, and lifelong learning habits.



CAREER READINESS

Prepare them for professional success beyond athletics.



PURPOSE & IDENTITY

Build a sense of self that is bigger than performance.



THE FUTURE STARTS NOW

The best time to prepare athletes for life after sport is while they are still playing. Every conversation, habit, and experience helps shape the person they become.

PREPARING TODAY FOR TOMORROW'S OPPORTUNITIES.

SUCCESS AFTER SPORT DOESN'T HAPPEN BY ACCIDENT.

The same focus, discipline, and resilience that help athletes excel on the field can help them thrive in school, careers, and life.

The IronMind Mentality™ encourages families to start early—intentionally building the skills, experiences, and mindset that open doors long after the game is over.

Plan early. Prepare intentionally.
Build a future without limits.



“When families connect daily choices to long-term goals, athletes develop direction, confidence, and the courage to pursue what's next.”



VISION

Help them see what's possible.



PLANNING

Create a path and take action.



DEVELOPMENT

Build essential skills every day.



OPPORTUNITY

Open doors to a lifetime of potential.

LIFE SKILLS THAT TRANSFER BEYOND THE GAME



PROBLEM SOLVING

Think critically and find solutions.



COMMUNICATION

Express ideas clearly and listen well.



TEAM WORK

Collaborate and lead with others.



TIME MANAGEMENT

Prioritize and stay organized.



ADAPTABILITY

Embrace change and keep growing.



SELF-DISCIPLINE

Stay committed to goals and values.



WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

- ✓ Encouraging good habits at home and school.
- ✓ Talking about goals beyond athletics.
- ✓ Exposing your athlete to new experiences.
- ✓ Building confidence through challenges.
- ✓ Supporting education and continuous learning.
- ✓ Teaching responsibility and independence.
- ✓ Celebrating progress, not just performance.



PARENT ACTIONS THAT MAKE A DIFFERENCE

- ✓ Have ongoing conversations: Ask about their interests, not just their scores.
- ✓ Explore opportunities: Camps, clubs, volunteering, internships.
- ✓ Encourage curiosity: Support questions and new ideas.
- ✓ Invest in growth: Books, courses, mentors, and experiences.
- ✓ Teach life skills: Finances, decision-making, and resilience.
- ✓ Empower ownership: Let them take the lead on their path.



REFLECT

What dreams or goals does your athlete have for their future?



WRITE IT DOWN

List 3 ways you can help your athlete prepare for life beyond sport.



TALK IT OVER

Ask your athlete:

- What excites you about the future?
- What skills do you want to build?
- How can I support you right now?

SKILLS TODAY. SUCCESS TOMORROW.

THE SKILLS ATHLETES BUILD NOW
ARE THE TOOLS THEY'LL USE FOR LIFE.

Athletics is one of the best classrooms in the world. It teaches commitment, teamwork, leadership, and how to handle pressure.

But these lessons don't just help on the field—they prepare athletes for college, careers, relationships, and life.

Our job as parents is to help them
transfer these lessons beyond sport.

“

When we help athletes connect their athletic experiences to life beyond sport, we give them a roadmap for a confident, purposeful future.



FOCUS

Stay committed to what matters.



RESILIENCE

Bounce back and keep moving forward.



LEADERSHIP

Influence and inspire others.



ADAPTABILITY

Adjust, learn, and grow.

TURNING ATHLETIC LESSONS INTO LIFE SKILLS



DISCIPLINE

Do what needs to be done, even when it's hard.



TEAMWORK

Work with others toward a shared goal.



CONFIDENCE

Believe in your abilities and take on challenges.



COMMUNICATION

Express ideas clearly and listen with respect.



TIME MANAGEMENT

Plan, prioritize, and make the most of your time.



PROFESSIONALISM

Show up prepared, beachable, and follow through.



WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE

- ✓ Encouraging effort that builds character.
- ✓ Giving responsibilities at home and in the community.
- ✓ Talking about how skills apply in school and work.
- ✓ Helping them reflect on wins, losses, and lessons.
- ✓ Celebrating growth, not just results.
- ✓ Connecting athletic experiences to future goals.



PARENT ACTIONS THAT MAKE A DIFFERENCE

- ✓ Ask the connection: How can you use that in another area?
- ✓ Provide real-world experiences: Jobs, volunteering projects.
- ✓ Teach reflection: What did you learn? What's next?
- ✓ Support exploration: Encourage them to try new things.
- ✓ Model lifelong learning: Show curiosity and growth yourself.
- ✓ Affirm their identity: You are more than an athlete.



REFLECT

What life skills has your athlete gained from sports?



WRITE IT DOWN

List 3 life skills your athlete is building right now.



TALK IT OVER

Ask your athlete:

- What one skill you're proud of?
- Where do you see that helping you in life?
- What skills do you want to keep developing?

CAREER READINESS ROADMAP

Your Path. Your Purpose. Your Future.

A step-by-step roadmap to help your athlete build the skills, explore options, and prepare for a meaningful future beyond sport.



Success after sport begins before sport ends.

— Ken Stoddart

PART 1

DISCOVER & EXPLORE

The first half of the journey is all about exploring who you are and what's possible.

[CONTINUES
ON PAGE 23](#)



1

SELF DISCOVERY

Know yourself first.

- Strengths
- Interests
- Values
- Personality
- What energizes you?

2



EXPLORE OPTIONS

Explore the possibilities.

- Career paths
- Education opportunities
- Trades & certifications
- Entrepreneurship
- Different lifestyles

3



BUILD SKILLS

Develop skills for life.

- Leadership
- Communication
- Problem solving
- Networking
- Time management

START HERE

Every great future begins with the right preparation today.



KEY REMINDER

You don't have to have it all figured out today. You just need to take the next right step.



PROGRESS OVER PERFECTION

Small steps today create big opportunities tomorrow.

CAREER READINESS ROADMAP

Your Path. Your Purpose. Your Future.

PART 2 PREPARE & TRANSITION

← CONTINUED FROM PAGE 22

Now we focus on building experience, connections, and a plan for the future.



4 BUILD YOUR NETWORK

Surround yourself with the right people.

- Mentors & role models
- Coaches & teachers
- LinkedIn & professional connections
- Industry & community contacts



5 GAIN EXPERIENCE

Experience opens doors.

- Internships & job shadowing
- Part-time jobs
- Volunteering & service
- Projects & real-world challenges



6 CREATE YOUR FUTURE PLAN

Design a future that excites you.

- Education pathway
- Career goals
- Life goals
- Personal mission & impact



“

Your athlete's next chapter deserves preparation too.

— Ken Stoddart



RESEARCH INSIGHT

Athletes who intentionally prepare for their future careers experience smoother transitions and stronger long-term wellbeing.

— Journal of Applied Sport Psychology

PARENT REFLECTION

How am I helping my athlete prepare for life beyond competition?



FUTURE READY ATHLETE

Prepared for life.
Ready for anything.

HOW TO USE THIS ROADMAP

- 1 **Start the Conversation**
Ask your athlete where they are and where they want to go.
- 2 **Identify the Next Step**
Focus on one stage at a time. Small steps create momentum.
- 3 **Take Action Together**
Explore, plan, and execute as a team.
- 4 **Review and Adjust**
Revisit regularly and adapt as they grow and evolve.

LinkedIn Checklist

Build their professional presence.

LinkedIn is the world's largest professional network. A strong profile helps athletes build their personal brand, connect with opportunities, and open doors for their future.

Use this checklist to create a profile that shows who they are and where they're going.



“

Your LinkedIn profile is your digital handshake. Make it professional. Make it you.

— Ken Stoddart

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel!™



LinkedIn Profile Checklist



1. Professional Profile Photo

Use a clear, professional headshot with a neutral background.

☐


2. Compelling Headline

Go beyond your job title. Highlight what you do and what you bring.

Example: Student-Athlete | Leader | Aspiring Sports Marketer

☐


3. About Section (Summary)

Tell your story. Share your background, passions, skills, and goals.

☐


4. Experience

List your roles, responsibilities, and achievements (athletics, school, work, volunteering).

☐


5. Education

Add your school, degree or program, and relevant coursework or honors.

☐


6. Skills

Add relevant skills (e.g., teamwork, leadership, communication, time management).

☐


7. Recommendations

Ask coaches, teachers, or mentors to write recommendations for you.

☐


8. Activity

Follow companies, engage with content, and comment thoughtfully.

☐


9. Customize Your URL

Create a clean, professional LinkedIn URL.

☐


Quick Tips



Be authentic. Share your story.



Highlight experiences, not just titles.



Use keywords that match your goals.



Keep your profile updated.



Engage with your network regularly.



What to Avoid



Using an unprofessional or no photo.



Leaving sections blank.



Spelling or grammar errors.



Overly casual language.



Exaggerating accomplishments.



YOUR PROFILE.
YOUR FUTURE.

A strong LinkedIn profile today can lead to mentorships, internships, opportunities, and a lifetime of connections.

NETWORKING WORKSHEET

CONNECTIONS CREATE OPPORTUNITIES.

Strong relationships open doors. This worksheet helps your athlete build meaningful connections, grow their network, and create opportunities for their future.

Great networks are built with genuine interest, respect, and consistency.



Your network is not just who you know. It's who knows you, who believes in your potential.

— KEN STODART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The
Athletic Identity Wheel™

THE 4 STEPS OF EFFECTIVE NETWORKING

1

CONNECT



Find people in your community, industry, school, or teams who inspire you.

2

ENGAGE



Start conversations. Ask questions. Listen and show genuine interest.

3

NURTURE



Stay in touch. Follow up. Share updates and support their work.

4

GIVE VALUE



Look for ways to help others. Add value before you ask for anything in return.

MY NETWORK MAP

List people who can support, mentor, or guide you in your journey.

NAME	HOW I KNOW THEM	HOW THEY CAN HELP ME

CONVERSATION STARTERS

Use these ideas to start meaningful conversations.

What do you enjoy most about your work?
How did you get started in your career?
What advice would you give someone like me?
What skills or experiences are most valuable in your field?
How can I keep learning and growing in this area?

PEOPLE I WANT TO MEET

Who would you like to connect with? Why?

NAME / ROLE	WHY I WANT TO CONNECT

MY ACTION PLAN

Take action. Small steps lead to big opportunities.

Who will I reach out to this month?

How will I connect with them?

When will I follow up?

How can I add value to this relationship?

PARENTS CAN HELP

Encourage conversations and help them overcome cynishness.

Introduce them to your network when appropriate.

Teach the importance of gratitude and follow-up.

Model strong networking through your actions.

Celebrate their efforts and progress.

THE MENTAL GAME™

MIND. FOCUS. RESILIENCE. CONFIDENCE.

Success in sport—and in life—starts in the mind. The Mental Game's about building the inner skills that help athletes stay focused, overcome challenges, and perform at their best.

Strong minds don't just happen. They're built—on purpose.



“

*Talent gets you noticed.
Mindset keeps you growing.
Mental strength keeps you competing.
Life skills keep you winning.*

— **KEN STODDART**

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel®

WHAT IS THE MENTAL GAME?

It's the set of mental skills that help athletes manage pressure, handle setbacks, stay motivated, and keep improving—on and off the field. These skills create confidence, clarity, and control.

CORE MENTAL SKILLS



FOCUS

Stay present. Block out distractions.
Direct your attention where it matters most.



CONFIDENCE

Believe in your abilities. "Trust your preparativeness.
Back yourself every time.



RESILIENCE

Bounce back stronger. Learn from setbacks and keep moving forward.



SELF-AWARENESS

Understand your thoughts, feelings, and beliefs. Know yourself.



MOTIVATION

Stay driven by purpose. Set meaningful goals and take action every day.



EMOTIONAL CONTROL

Manage emotions. Stay calm under pressure. Respond, don't react.

MINDSET MATTERS

HOW ATHLETES THINK SHAPES HOW THEY PERFORM.

Your athlete's mindset affects how they train, compete, handle setbacks, and grow. A strong mindset doesn't just lead to better performance—it builds resilience for life.

The good news? Mindset is something your athlete can develop every day.



“

The mental part of the game is where champions are made. Train your mind with the same purpose you train your body.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel!



GROWTH MINDSET VS. FIXED MINDSET

GROWTH MINDSET

- Believes abilities can improve with effort and practice.
- Embrace challenges and see them as opportunities.
- Learns from mistakes and keeps trying.
- Sees effort as the path to mastery.
- Inspired by others' success and uses it for motivation.

FIXED MINDSET

- Believes abilities are set and can't change.
- Avoids challenges and fears failure.
- Gives up easily after setbacks.
- Sees effort as a sign they're not good enough.
- Feels threatened by others' success.

KEY MINDSET SHIFTS

I can't do it.	I can't do it... yet.
I give up.	I'll keep going.
I made a mistake.	Mistakes help me learn.
This is too hard.	This will challenge me.
They're better than me.	I can learn from their success.

HOW PARENTS CAN SUPPORT A STRONG MINDSET

PRaise EFFORT, NOT OUTCOMES

Focus on hard work, improvement, and perseverance.

ENCOURAGE CHALLENGES

Help them step out of their comfort zone and grow.

NORMALIZE SETBACKS

Share stories of resilience and remind them failure is part of the journey.

ASK BETTER QUESTIONS

Ask "What did you learn?" instead of "How did you do?"

MODEL A POSITIVE MINDSET

Your attitude toward challenges influences their mindset.

FOCUS ON THE PROCESS

Celebrate daily habits that lead to long-term success.

**STRONG MINDS,
STRONG FUTURES.**

A strong mindset today builds confidence, resilience, and belief—for sport and for life.

THE MENTAL SKILLS FRAMEWORK

Train Your Mind. Elevate Your Game. Enrich Your Life.

Mental skills are the hidden edge every athlete needs to perform at their best, handle pressure, and reach their potential.

“

Your athlete's mind is their greatest competitive advantage.

— Ken Stoddart

PART 1 CORE MENTAL SKILLS

Strong performance starts with a strong mind. These core skills form the foundation for everything your athlete does.



1 FOCUS

Control your attention. Stay present.

- Attention
- Presence
- Concentration



2 CONFIDENCE

Believe in your preparation. Trust yourself.

- Self-belief
- Preparation
- Trust



3 RESILIENCE

Bounce back stronger from setbacks.

- Bounce back
- Adapt
- Grow



KEY REMINDER

Develop mental skills is a daily practice, not a one-time event.



These are the foundation. Now we build on them.

CONTINUES
ON PAGE 29

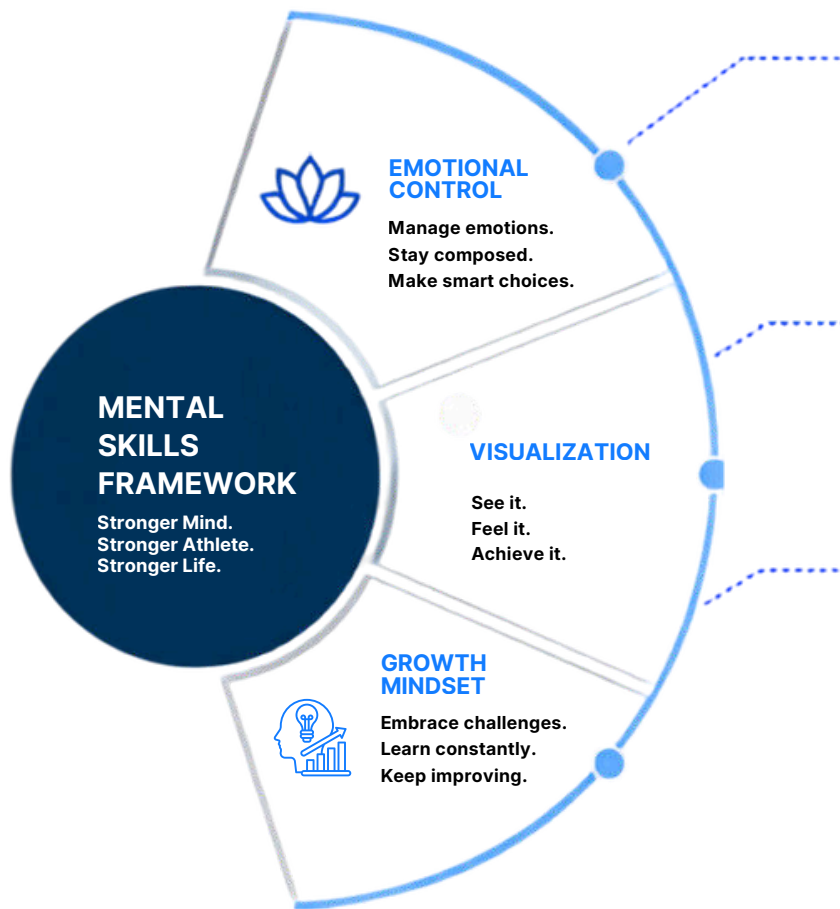
**STRONG MINDS
BUILD STRONG FUTURES.**

Master the mind.
Master the moments.
Master your future.

THE MENTAL SKILLS FRAMEWORK

Train Your Mind. Elevate Your Game. Enrich Your Life.

These skills help your athlete stay composed, visualize success, and grow through every experience.



**Master the Mind.
Master the Game.
Master Life.**

Mental skills aren't just for sport.
They build character, confidence,
and a future of unlimited potential.

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

Choose one mental skill from the framework and help your athlete practice it intentionally this week.

Choose | Practice | Reflect | Improve



RESEARCH INSIGHT

Athletes who consistently develop mental skills show higher performance, greater resilience, and stronger long-term wellbeing.

— Journal of Applied Sport Psychology

← CONTINUED FROM PAGE 28

You've built the foundation. Now it's time to strengthen your athlete's mindset for long-term success and a life beyond sport.

PART 2

GROWTH & PERFORMANCE SKILLS

These skills take your athlete's mind to the next level. They create growth, control, and lasting impact.

4 EMOTIONAL CONTROL

Manage emotions.
Stay composed.

- Self-awareness
- Regulation
- Composure



5 VISUALIZATION

See success before it happens.

- Mental rehearsal
- Positive imagery
- Increased confidence



6 GROWTH MINDSET

Believe in growth.
Embrace every challenge.

- Learn
- Adapt
- Improve



PARENT REFLECTION

Which mental skill do you believe would have the biggest impact on your athlete right now?

The strongest athletes aren't just physically tough, they're mentally prepared.

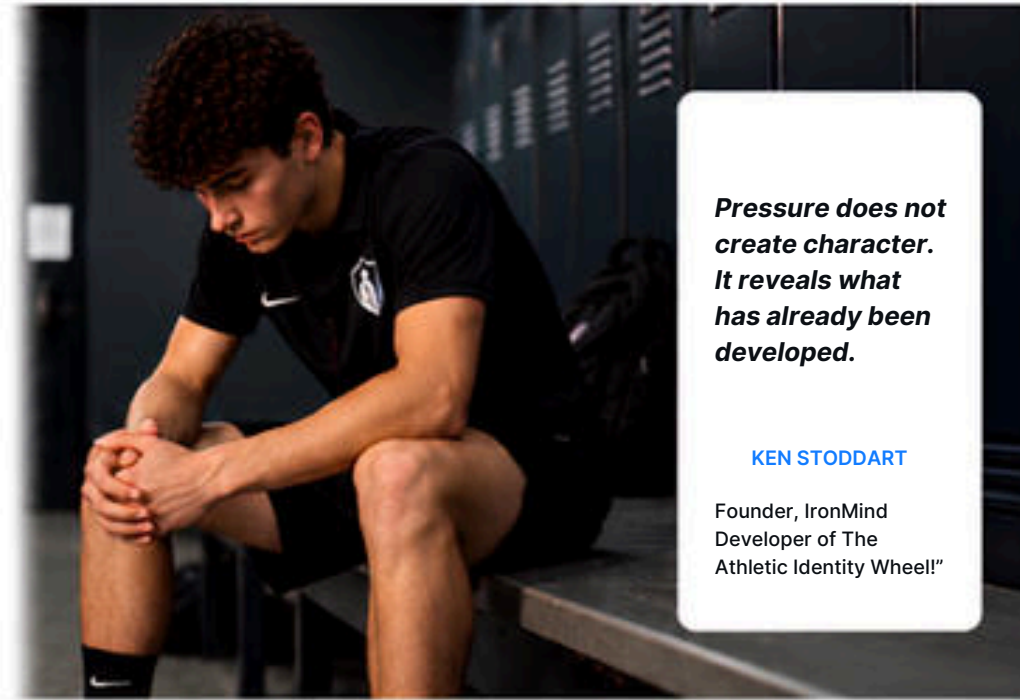
— Ken Stoddart

WHEN PRESSURE SHOWS UP

HELPING ATHLETES RESPOND INSTEAD OF REACT

Pressure is part of sport. How your athlete responds to it makes all the difference.

Preparation builds confidence.
Mindset determines the response.



**Pressure does not
create character.
It reveals what
has already been
developed.**

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The
Athletic Identity Wheel!"

THE THREE COMMON RESPONSES TO PRESSURE



FIGHT

Athlete becomes
frustrated.

SIGNS

Anger
Blaming others
Emotional reactions



PARENT RESPONSE

Stay calm. Help them
process before correcting.



FREEZE

Athlete
shuts down.

SIGNS

Self-doubt
Hestation
Fear of mistakes



PARENT RESPONSE

Restore confidence.
Focus on effort and preparation.



FLIGHT

Athlete wants to
avoid challenges.

SIGNS

Quitting
Avoiding competition
Loss of motivation



PARENT RESPONSE

Reconnect them with
purpose and goals.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

Athletes who learn coping skills and emotional regulation demonstrate greater resilience, confidence, and long-term performance than athletes who rely solely on talent.

Source: American Psychological Association (APA)

REFLECTION FOR PARENTS

- ☐ How does my athlete typically respond under pressure?
- ☐ Which response pattern appears most often?
- ☐ What support do they need from me in difficult moments?
- ☐ Do I increase pressure or reduce it?

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE

After your athlete's
next competition:

Do not ask:
Did you win?

Instead ask:

What did you learn?
What challenged you?
What are you proud of?

**GREAT ATHLETES TRAIN THEIR BODIES.
ELITE ATHLETES TRAIN THEIR MINDS.**

CONTROL WHAT YOU CAN

FOCUS. EFFORT. ATTITUDE. RESULTS WILL FOLLOW.

Worrying about things you can't control creates stress. Focusing on what you can control creates confidence.

Great athletes focus on their circle, not the noise outside it.



You have no control over what happens to you, but you have complete control over how you respond.

KEN STODDART

Founder, IronMind
Developer of The Athletic Identity Wheel™

THE CIRCLE OF CONTROL

FOCUS HERE. WIN HERE.



EFFORT

Give your best in every rep, every drill, every moment.



FOCUS

Stay present. Block distractions. Be where your feet are.



ATTITUDE

Choose positivity. Stay coachable. Bring energy every day.



PREPARATION

Study the game. Train smart. Be ready before it's time.



RESPONSE

Control your emotions. Respond with maturity.

WHY IT MATTERS

The best athletes don't just react to the game... they manage their mindset through it.



REFLECTION FOR ATHLETES

What is something I can control today?

What usually distracts me from my focus?

How can I improve my response in tough moments?

What is one habit I will control this week?

CONTROL YOUR MINDSET. CONTROL YOUR FUTURE.

PARENT ACTION

Help your athlete stay in their circle. Encourage what they can control. Let go of what they can't.

Praise effort, not outcome.

Ask questions, not judgment.

Support their mindset, not pressure it.

THE HOME ENVIRONMENT SCORECARDTM

THE ENVIRONMENT BUILDS THE ATHLETE.

Athletes don't just grow in the gym or on the field.
They grow at home.
Use this scoreboard to evaluate the mental environment
you create every day.

Awareness is the first step. Action is what changes everything.



The best athletes aren't just trained on the field.
They're supported, challenged, and believed in at home.

RATE YOUR HOME ENVIRONMENT

Rate each area honestly based on your home right now.

1 = Rare 2 = Sometimes 3 = Often 4 = Always

	EMOTIONAL SAFETY	My athlete feels safe to share how they feel without fear of criticism.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐
	POSITIVE COMMUNICATION	We communicate in a respectful, encouraging, and supportive way.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐
	EFFORT OVER OUTCOME	We focus more on my athlete's effort, growth, and learning than on results.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐
	MENTAL SUPPORT	I help my athlete manage pressure, setbacks, and tough moments.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐
	HEALTHY ROUTINES	Our home routines support sleep, recovery, nutrition, and balance.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐
	UNCONDITIONAL SUPPORT	My love and support for my athlete is not based on performance.	1 ☐	2 ☐	3 ☐	4 ☐

TOTAL YOUR SCORE: / 24

20-24 = Strong Environment | 12-19 = Room to Grow | 0-11 = Needs Attention
Every point above 12 is a step toward building a champion at home.

Building a champion at home

the home environment is the foundation.

Talent gets athletes noticed.
Mindset, habits, and support help them last.
Your daily actions shape their identity, confidence, and future.
Small things. Done consistently. Create greatness.



“Behind every resilient athlete is an intentional home environment.

— Ken Stoddart

the champion home checklist



1. Create emotional safety

Make your home a place where your athlete feels safe to be honest, make mistakes, and express emotions.

☐


2. Communicate with purpose

Listen more than you talk. Ask better questions. Communicate in a respectful, supportive way.

☐


3. Praise effort, not outcome

Recognize hard work, improvement, and character. Don't attach your happiness to their performance.

☐


4. Support the mental game

Help your athlete build confidence, focus, resilience, and emotional control — on and off the field.

☐


5. Establish healthy routines

Consistent sleep, nutrition, recovery, school, and downtime fuel their mind and body.

☐


6. Be their biggest fan, not coach

Encourage. Believe. Support. Leave the coaching to their coach. You bring the love.

☐

REFLECTION FOR PARENTS

What is one thing my athlete needs more of from me?

What is one thing I may be doing that adds pressure?

How does my behavior impact my athlete's confidence?

What changes can I make to create a stronger environment at home?

THIS WEEK'S ACTION PLAN

One conversation

Schedule one intentional conversation with your athlete this week.

When? _____

Notes: _____

One encouragement

Give one specific encouragement focused on effort, attitude, or growth.

When? _____

Notes: _____

One positive habit

Implement one new habit that supports your athlete's success.

When? _____

Notes: _____

THE CONVERSATION NO ONE WANTS TO HAVE

Preparing for life after sport is not pessimistic. It is one of the most important gifts a parent can give their athlete.

Every athlete experiences a final game.
A final practice. A final season. A final chapter.

Yet most families spend years preparing for competition and almost no time preparing for transition.

The result is often confusion, identity loss, anxiety, and uncertainty about what comes next.
The goal is not to move athletes away from sport.

The goal is to help them build a life that is bigger than sport.

“Preparing for the future isn’t giving up on the present.”

KEN STODART



ATHLETIC IDENTITY

Who am I when I am not competing?

Athletes need help discovering who they are beyond the jersey, the scoreboard, and the spotlight.



PURPOSE

What gives me life meaning beyond performance?

Purpose provides direction, motivation, and fulfillment that outlast any sport.



FUTURE READINESS

What skills and opportunities am I building for tomorrow?

Life skills, education, relationships, and real-world experiences create lasting opportunity.

FOR PARENTS

☐ Have we ever discussed life after athletics?

☐ What would my athlete struggle with most if sport ended tomorrow?

☐ How prepared are we for that conversation?

This conversation is not about the end of sport.
It’s about the beginning of everything else.

Start early.
Stay open.
Make it normal.
Make it a team effort.

WHAT IF THE GAME ENDED TOMORROW?



The Question Most Families Avoid



Every athlete eventually faces a final whirlle.

For some, it arrives after high school.
For others, after college.
For a very small percentage,
after a professional career.



But it arrives for everyone.

The challenge is not that sport ends.
The challenge is when an athlete
has never prepared for who they will
be after it ends.



When identity becomes dependent on performance, every setback feels personal.

Every injury feels catastrophic.
Every transition feels like losing
a part of yourself.



The healthiest athletes learn something different:

Sport is part of who they are.
It is not all of who they are.

"The end of a sports career
should never feel like the end
of a person."

– Ken Stoddart



RESEARCH INSIGHT

Athletes who develop identity beyond
sport demonstrate stronger resilience
during injury, retirement, and major
life transitions.

– Journal of Applied Sport Psychology



PARENT REFLECTION

If my athlete could no longer compete tomorrow...
what parts of their identity would remain strongest?

THIS WEEK'S ACTION

Ask your athlete:

"What are three things you love about
yourself that have nothing to do with sport?"

Listen.

Do not
correct.

Do not
coach.

Simply listen.

**SPORT IS SOMETHING THEY DO.
IT IS NOT ALL THEY ARE.**

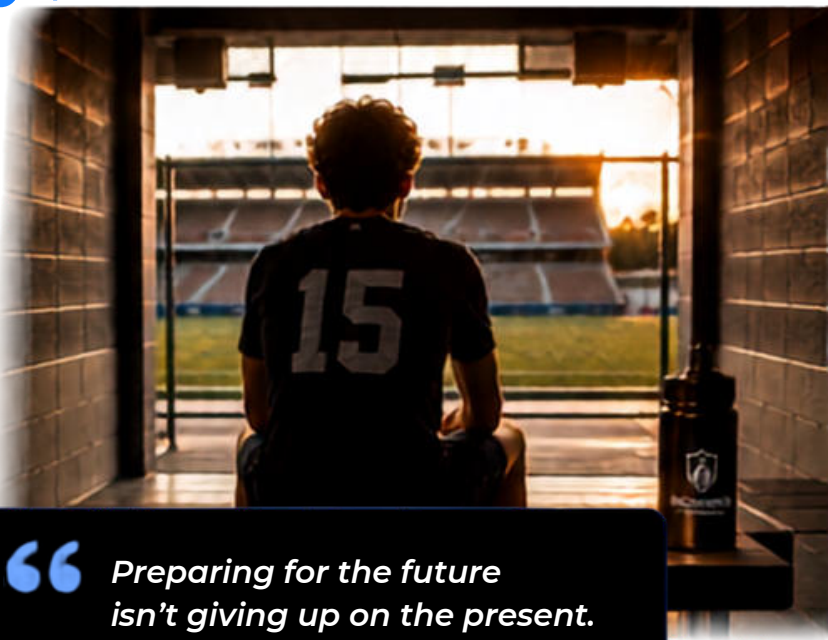
PREPARING BEFORE THE FINAL WHISTLE

TRANSITION READINESS DOESN'T HAPPEN BY ACCIDENT—IT HAPPENS BY DESIGN.

The best time to prepare for life after sport is while your athlete is still in the game.

Preparation today creates confidence, options, and purpose for tomorrow.

As a parent, you play a powerful role in helping your athlete build a life that is meaningful, fulfilling, and ready for what's next.



“Preparing for the future isn't giving up on the present.”

KEN STODDART

WHY EARLY PREPARATION MATTERS



REDUCES UNCERTAINTY

Knowing what could come next reduces fear of the unknown.



BUILDS OPTIONS

Exploring interests and skills now creates more doors later.



STRENGTHENS CONFIDENCE

Success in other areas builds belief beyond sport.



CREATES BALANCE

A well-rounded life during sport leads to a smoother transition.



DEVELOPS PURPOSE

Purpose gives athletes direction when their season ends.

WHAT YOUR ATHLETE CAN DO NOW

EXPLORE INTERESTS

Encourage new experiences, hobbies, and activities outside of sport.

BUILD SKILLS

Invest time in developing life skills, leadership, communication, and independence.

FOCUS ON EDUCATION

Stay engaged in school and explore learning that goes beyond the game.

EXPAND CONNECTIONS

Build relationships with people who inspire and support growth.

PLAN AND SET GOALS

Think about short-term and long-term goals beyond athletics.

PARENT ACTION PLAN

START THE CONVERSATION

Create a safe space to talk about life.

MY ACTION: _____

LISTEN WITH EMPATHY

Listen to their hopes, fears, and dreams for the future.

MY ACTION: _____

ENCOURAGE EXPLORATION

Supports the development of interests and learning new things.

MY ACTION: _____

CONNECT THEM

Introduce them to mentors, role models, and community activities.

MY ACTION: _____

STAY INVOLVED

Continue showing up, supporting, and believing in them.

MY ACTION: _____

REFLECTIO FOR PARENTS

What do I hope my athlete's life looks like after their time in sport?

What steps can our family take right now to prepare for the future?

IDENTITY TRANSITION MAP

Preparing For The Next Chapter

Transitions don't happen overnight. They are a journey. This map helps your athlete build a strong identity before, during, and after sport.

“ PULL QUOTE

“Preparing for the future isn't giving up on the present.”

— Ken Stoddart

THE TRANSITION JOURNEY

CONTINUES ON
PAGE 38



PHASE 1

BEFORE THE SHIFT

Build Awareness. Build Options. Build Confidence.



1. KNOW YOURSELF

Encourage your athlete to explore their values, interests, strengths, and what matters most to them.



2. EXPLORE POSSIBILITIES

Expose them to new experiences, careers, education paths, and life outside of sport.



3. DEVELOP SKILLS

Support them in building transferable skills: communication, leadership, time management, curiosity, and resilience.

START HERE

MINDSET CHECK

Shift the focus from:

“What can sport do for me?”

To:

“What can I become?”



PHASE 2

DURING THE SHIFT

Stay Grounded. Stay Open. Stay Growing.



Validate emotions. It's okay to grieve the change.



Focus on progress, not perfection. Small steps build momentum.



Lean on your support system. You don't have to navigate it alone.



THIS TRANSITION IS NOT AN END.
IT'S AN EXPANSION.

You are not losing an identity. You are building a life. And that is worth preparing for.

IDENTITY TRANSITION MAP

Preparing For The Next Chapter



PHASE 3

AFTER THE SHIFT

Rebuild. Redefine. Reinvent.



1. REDEFINE IDENTITY

Help your athlete discover strengths, values, and passions beyond sport.



2. SET NEW GOALS

Support them in setting meaningful goals aligned with their new chapter.



3. BUILD COMMUNITY

Encourage new connections and relationships that fuel growth and belonging.



4. CREATE PURPOSE

Help them find ways to contribute, serve, and make an impact.



PHASE 4

BEYOND THE GAME

Live. Lead. Leave a Legacy.



Live with confidence in who they are.



Lead with their experiences and values.



Inspire others through their journey.



Leave a legacy that goes beyond sport.

NEW
CHAPTER

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 37

The second half of the journey focuses on building a future that feels meaningful, exciting, and true to who your athlete is becoming.

IDENTITY ANCHORS

Use these anchors to help your athlete stay grounded through every transition.



VALUES

What matters most to me?



STRENGTHS

What am I naturally good at?



PASSIONS

What lights me up?



PEOPLE

Who supports and inspires me?



PURPOSE

How do I want to make a difference?

PARENT REFLECTION

How can I best support my athlete through their next chapter?

RESEARCH INSIGHT

Athletes who prepare for identity transitions report higher life satisfaction, stronger mental health, and greater success in future endeavors.

— *Journal of Applied Sport Psychology*

Transitions are not the end of the story. They are the beginning of becoming everything you were created to be.

— Ken Stoddart

30-DAY IRONMIND PARENT PLAYBOOK™

SMALL ACTIONS.
STRONGER
CONVERSATIONS.
BIGGER FUTURES.

The strongest families build connection through consistent daily actions.

This 30-day playbook is designed to help you strengthen communication, identity, confidence, and future readiness.



*Consistency in small moments
creates transformation in their future.*

KEN STODDART

30-DAY CHALLENGE

WEEK 1 CONNECT

- ☐ Ask open-ended questions
- ☐ Listen without solving
- ☐ Celebrate effort
- ☐ Share a family story
- ☐ Reflect together

WEEK 2 GROW

- ☐ Discuss strengths
- ☐ Explore interests
- ☐ Build independence
- ☐ Encourage curiosity
- ☐ Set one personal goal

WEEK 3 PREPARE

- ☐ Talk about the future
- ☐ Identify life skills
- ☐ Connect with mentors
- ☐ Discuss opportunities
- ☐ Practice gratitude

WEEK 4 LEAD

- ☐ Revisit family values
- ☐ Create a future vision
- ☐ Reflect on growth
- ☐ Celebrate progress
- ☐ Commit to next steps

THIS MONTH I LEARNED:

MY BIGGEST TAKEAWAY:

THIS MONTH I COMMIT TO:

SIGNATURE:/DATE:

MY FAMILY FOCUS:

ONE ACTION I WILL TAKE DAILY:

**SMALL ACTIONS
TODAY.**

**STRONGER FUTURES
TOMORROW.**

FINISH STRONG. BUILD LASTING CHANGE.

WEEK 3 & WEEK 4 ACTION PLAN

The last two weeks are about deepening conversations, strengthening habits, and preparing your athlete for a life of purpose, confidence, and impact.

Small, consistent actions today create
a future your athlete will thank you for.



WEEK 3: BUILD MOMENTUM (DAYS 15-21)

DAILY ACTIONS

- ☐ Day 15 Discuss future goals beyond sport.
- ☐ Day 16 Explore one new career interest.
- ☐ Day 17 Practice gratitude together.
- ☐ Day 18 Identify transferable skills from sport.
- ☐ Day 19 Connect with a mentor or role model.
- ☐ Day 20 Reflect on growth this season.
- ☐ Day 21 Celebrate progress made so far.



WEEK 4: FINISH STRONG (DAYS 22-30)

DAILY ACTIONS

- ☐ Day 22 Discuss purpose and impact.
- ☐ Day 23 Explore educational opportunities.
- ☐ Day 24 Build a future-focused vision board.
- ☐ Day 25 Talk about life after athletics.
- ☐ Day 26 Practice independent decision-making.
- ☐ Day 27 Strengthen family communication.
- ☐ Day 28 Revisit the Identity Transition Map'tl.
- ☐ Day 29 Create next-step goals.
- ☐ Day 30 Celebrate growth and commit to the future.

MONTHLY REFLECTION

Take time to reflect on your journey over the last 30 days.

What conversation made the biggest impact?

What did I learn about my athlete?

What did my athlete learn about themselves?

What habits do we want to continue?

PARENT SCORECARD

HOW WELL AM I SUPPORTING MY ATHLETE BEYOND SPORT?



SCORE EACH
AREA:

1 = Rare

4 = Strong

2 = Sometimes

5 = Exceptional

3 = Consistently

YOUR SCORE

Communication /5

Identity Development /5

Future Readiness /5

Emotional Support /5

TOTAL /25

SCORE INTERPRETATION



IRONMIND PARENT LEADER

You are building an environment where athletes thrive beyond sport.



16 – 20 STRONG FOUNDATION

Continue strengthening consistency and intentional conversations.



11-15 GROWTH OPPORTUNITY

Several important areas deserve greater attention.



5-10 TIME TO REBUILD

Start with communication and identity development first.

COMMUNICATION



- ☐ I ask more than I lecture.
- ☐ I ask questions instead of giving answers.
- ☐ My athletes feel safe talking to me.
- ☐ We regularly discuss life beyond sport.

1 2 3 4 5

IDENTITY DEVELOPMENT



- ☐ I remind my athletes they are more than their sport.
- ☐ I celebrate character as much as performance.
- ☐ We discuss values and purpose regularly.
- ☐ I support interests outside athletics.

1 2 3 4 5

FUTURE READINESS



- ☐ We discuss education and career goals.
- ☐ My athletes are developing life skills.
- ☐ We encourage exploration beyond athletics.
- ☐ We actively prepare for future transitions.

1 2 3 4 5

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT



- ☐ I stay calm during challenges.
- ☐ I focus on growth after setbacks.
- ☐ We focus on effort more than outcomes.
- ☐ I help my athlete process emotions.

1 2 3 4 5

FAMILY ENVIRONMENT



- ☐ Our home encourages open communication. Mistakes are treated as learning opportunities.
- ☐ Success is not tied solely to performance.
- ☐ Our family values growth and character.

Score:

1 2 3 4 5

REFLECTION

Take a moment to reflect on your score.

What is my greatest strength as a parent?

What is one area I will improve this month?

This month I will intentionally support my athlete beyond performance.

SIGNATURE: _____

DATE: _____

Family Mission Statement

Defining who we are, what we stand for, and how we will grow together

Strong families do not leave culture to chance.
They create it intentionally.

A Family Mission Statement helps your athlete understand the values, beliefs, and standards that guide decisions both in sport and in life.



Championship cultures are built intentionally. So are championship families.

— Ken Stoddart



Our Family Values

Choose 5 values that matter most.

- | | |
|---|-------------------------------------|
| ☐ Integrity | ☐ Gratitude |
| ☐ Discipline | ☐ Leadership |
| ☐ Respect | ☐ Kindness |
| ☐ Courage | ☐ Resilience |
| ☐ Accountability | ☐ Service |
| ☐ Growth | ☐ Excellence |

List Your top 5 values here:

Who do we want to become?

As a family, we want to be known for:

What will we commit to?

We will:

1

2

3

4

5

Our Family Motto

A short phrase that defines us:

Parent Reflection

Take time to reflect as a family.

What values matter most to our family?

What lessons do we want our athlete to remember forever?

How do we define success beyond winning?

What legacy do we want to leave?

PARENT SIGNATURE:

ATHLETE SIGNATURE:

DATE:



FAMILY COMMITMENT

We commit to living our values, upholding our standards, and supporting each other every day.

The Letter That Changes Everything

One day, your athlete will remember very little about the scores.
They may forget the statistics.
They may forget the rankings.
They may even forget the championships.

But they will never forget how you made them feel.

Long after the final whistle, the most valuable gift you can give your athlete is your words.

Not words about performance.
Not words about winning.
Words about who they are.

- Their character.
- Their courage.
- Their growth.
- Their impact on others.

This page begins one of the most meaningful exercises in the entire IronMind journey.

A letter from parent to athlete.

A letter they may carry with them for the rest of their life.

“

One day every athlete faces a final whistle.

The question isn't what they accomplished.

The question is who they became.

Ken Stoddart

Before you write

Take a moment and consider:


☐

What am I most proud of beyond my athlete's performance?


☐

What character traits do I admire most?


☐

What do I hope they remember years from now?


☐

What message do they need to hear today?

Tomorrow,

You will write a letter that your athlete may remember forever.

Turn the page.

Performance fades. Character lasts.



A LETTER TO MY ATHLETE

THE WORDS THEY MAY
CARRY FOREVER

Use this space to write a message your athlete can return to throughout their life.

- ✓ Focus on character.
- ✓ Focus on growth.
- ✓ Focus on who they are becoming.

Write from the heart.

Be proud
Be you
Be more
than the
game.
♡

Dear _____,

Love,

Parent / Guardian _____ Date _____



If you are stuck,
start here:



What makes me
proud of you?



What character traits
do I admire most?



What challenges have
you overcome?



What do I hope you
never forget?



What do I believe is
possible for your future?



Who are you beyond
your sport?

Your Athlete is More Than Their Sport.

At The Athlete Check, we believe parents have the power to shape identity, build character, and prepare their athlete for a life of purpose beyond sport.

This playbook is your first step.
[The IronMind journey continues.](#)
We're with you every step of the way.



Identity Gain OS for Corporate Executives



The complete identity development system that helps student athletes build confidence, clarity, and purpose beyond sport.



Scan to
learn more



IronMind for Student Athletes'



Daily lessons, tools, and frameworks to build a strong mind, strong character, and an unstoppable future.



Scan to learn
more



Strong minds. Strong
character. Strong families.
Stronger futures.

*Thank you for being
the greatest influence
in your athlete's life.*



Visit our home base:
TheAthleteCheck.com